

network. While the registration process is usually quite short for most sites, some registration forms can be quite complex with optional questions ranging from previous employers to favorite meals. Unfortunately it is not always clear what information is required or optional when registering with a site.

There are some sites where an existing connection to a user on a site is required before membership to that site can be obtained. For example, to become a member of orkut, a non-member would have to contact a friend or acquaintance who is already a member of the site and ask for an invite, or alternatively an existing member would send an invitation to a non-member to join the site. This seems to keep down the number of inactive accounts. eBay auctioneers were quick to cash in on the rush to become a member of the Internet's hottest community site, selling invitations to join orkut in the same way that low ICQ numbers or short domain names previously changed hands in auctions.

To establish a link with another user on a social networking site usually requires the agreement of that user. For example, on Spoke, an e-mail invitation message is sent to another user with whom a connection is to be created. There are a few sites where this is not the case. Word of Mouth is an example of a site which does not require both users to register with the site to establish a link: the link is established by simply entering the e-mail address of the person with whom to create a link.

2.2 User Profiles

Social vs. Professional.

User profiles are a means of providing an identity for users online. The type of information entered determines the type of profile that users of social and business networking sites will share and use. Business profiles allow professionals to interact with one another through business orientated information, endorsements, testimonials and reputations. This allows business professionals, owners and entrepreneurs to connect together and search for contacts by location or expertise. Social networking profiles are built